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Rajasthan's Sikar town, 22-year-old Pradeep Meghwal had spent three years preparing for NEET-UG (National Eligibility cum Entrance Test-Undergraduate) for admissions to medical colleges. He was confident he would make it to a top institute this year. Instead, he died by suicide at his home on May 15, three days after the exam, conducted earlier on May 3, was cancelled following a paper leak. Twenty-one-year-old Ritik Mishra took the same route in Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri, as the cancelled exam put an end to what was his third attempt too. Twenty-year-old Anshika Pandey, who had missed a seat by four marks last time, could not bear the collapse of her third attempt either and ended her life in Delhi's Azadpur. In Goa, a 17-year-old boy could not handle the pressure of preparing for competitive exams while holding on to his love for hockey. He, too, chose death over uncertainty.

Four young lives, each representing the human cost of a broken examination system, conducted by the National Testing Agency (NTA), India's premier testing body, which was twice told to mend its ways but did not. NEET-UG 2026 was a single-day, pen-and-paper examination for nearly 2.28 million aspirants across more than 5,400 centres in 565 cities. At stake were 129,805 MBBS seats in 824 medical colleges and 27,695 BDS seats in 330 dental colleges.

Within days of the test, a handwritten "guess paper" of about 410 questions started doing the rounds. It had been circulating on WhatsApp and Telegram before the exam. Some students reportedly received it 42 hours in advance, others nearly a month earlier. A whistleblower in Sikar compared it with the official booklet and found a near-perfect overlap, accounting for 600 of the total 720 marks.

The NTA's own internal review found the leaked material to be identical in the case of the Chemistry paper and matching substantial portions of the Biology questionnaire too. Around 120 questions from the "guess paper" had appeared in the actual test. On May 12, the NTA cancelled the exam across the country, for the first time in its history. The re-examination will now be held on June 21.

THE NOT SO NEET PROCESS

The National Eligibility cum Entrance Test-Undergraduate (NEET-UG) is a pen-and-paper common entrance exam for medical aspirants. Here is the process and where the lapses happen:

QUESTION PAPER SETTING

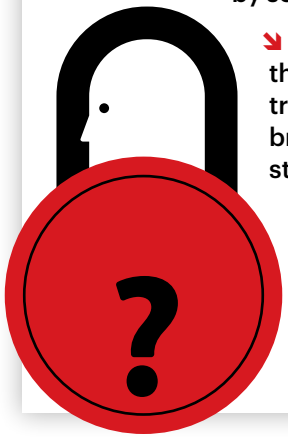


- The National Medical Commission (NMC) notifies the syllabus, which is then published on the National Testing Agency (NTA) and NMC websites
- Subject experts create a pool of questions. Experienced educators and examiners review them for difficulty, relevance and quality. Question papers are translated from English to 12 Indian languages

POINT OF BREACH: The 2026 leak occurred at this stage, when paper-setters and translators allegedly leaked a set of questions

PRINTING AND TRANSPORTATION

- Once finalised, question papers are printed at secure facilities. OMR (optical mark recognition) sheets are printed separately, matched with the papers and sealed in GPS-trackable trunks with electronic locks. These are kept under CCTV surveillance and guarded by security personnel



- Less than a week before the exam, the NTA sends the trunks to designated bank branches, where they are stored in safe vaults. GPS tracking is used to monitor the movement in real time. The trunks are brought to the exam centre just before the exam

Illustrations by **TANMOY CHAKRABORTY**